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Rossano Sportiello

Pianist Rossano Sportiello was born on June 1, 1974 in Vigevano, Italy. He learned classical piano in a conservatory setting while absorbing jazz and popular music on gigs in Milan. Rossano records and performs frequently on the Arbors label with bassist Nicki Parrott and drummer Eddie Metz. His musicianship and personal convictions represent the art of jazz performance at its highest level.

Rossano was interviewed in New Hartford, NY on October 2, 2015 by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we are actually in the Hampton Inn in New Hartford. I have Rossano Sportiello with me today on the occasion of Fallcoming Jazz 2015 at Hamilton College. Thanks for spending time with me.

RS: It's a pleasure and as we say in Italy, *buongiorno*.

MR: I won't try to say that because it won't sound as good. Yesterday I was listening to two different recordings that you did. And on one you were playing "A Well-Tempered Clavier." How do you say that?

RS: Yeah, in Italian we say, "*Un Clavicembalo ben temperato*." The Well-Tempered Clavier. Yeah. I recorded a prelude in one of my CDs, just as a piano solo.

MR: That's what I was listening to. And then I put on "The St. Louis Blues" that you did with Nicki and Eddie.

RS: Right.

MR: And you were wailing. And there was one part where it sounded like you were playing like the horn section in the Basie band.

RS: Oh my goodness.

MR: So I was wondering if you like one better than the other.

RS: You mean classical and jazz? Well you know the thing is that I was trained as a classical piano player you know. I graduated at the conservatory in Italy. But my problem with classical was that I never felt the freedom that I could feel by playing popular music or, even better, jazz. And so after the graduation in classical music I stopped almost completely for a few years to play classical and I concentrated only in jazz. But then in the back of my mind there was always like a kind of bothering feeling like I thought it was just too bad to let all that go. And so I said what about if I try little by little to play maybe my recitals, just one classical tune per night. You know? And try to approach classical music with a kind of interior freedom that I normally feel when I play jazz. Now

you possess the song. So that's why I think you feel so comfortable. With a movement of a Beethoven sonata, you know, where you have to play exactly everything the way it is written and you have to try to get as close as you can to the idea of the composer, that's a different task. So they say that some of the greatest classical music performers, when they played one of the great pieces of the repertoire, they made it sound like it was improvised. Because they knew the music so well from the inside, that it almost sounded like they were just making it up on the spot. And so little by little I think I was able to acquire a little bit more freedom in classical music because of — in other words, the jazz thing made me understand how to approach the classical. So my motto is actually you should be playing jazz like classical music because that is where you get the finesse. And then classical music, like jazz, because it has to sound spontaneous. That's my motto. But I know that many people might not agree with that, but it works for me.

MR: Right. It's pretty profound. Did you have professors or piano teachers — the classical piano teachers, did they make an issue of you being a jazz player at the same time?

RS: I had only one classical piano teacher. From the beginning, I was age 9 until the final graduation at age 22, and he never was difficult that way. He always let me do what I wanted as far as I would practice also the regular stuff. I mean Beethoven and Chopin and Bach and so on. And as a matter of fact I think that he was also interested, mildly interested, in jazz. But somehow the way he was brought up was too far away from the mentality of a jazz pianist improvising. But I think that inside he might have thought I wish I could do that. In fact, shortly before he passed away one day I went to see him on one of my trips in Italy a few years ago. And he said, "you know it's been a couple of years that I was fooling around with 'Rhapsody in Blue' by Gershwin." That of course is not jazz, but among the so-called classical repertoire it's one of those pieces that goes in that direction. And so he said, "finally now I understood the piece and I'm enjoying it. I'm enjoying the harmony." And so I felt my goodness, finally he made it to the other side. And then a couple of months after that unfortunately he passed away.

MR: Oh. Well I'm glad he had that experience. It sort of opened his ears a little bit.

RS: Yeah, yeah.

MR: When you play, like a Bach piece we had mentioned, do you see the chords going by as you play it?

RS: Yeah. That should be the proper way to do it. With any classical music composition, you know, the performer should always be aware of where is the melodic line and how the harmony is developing. Because if you know very well that, that means that you really possess the piece. You can make a mistake but if you know the chords and the way the melodic line develops you won't get lost. The problem of getting lost with classical

music happens when you learn the piece just in your fingers. Then if you make a mistake the old finger memory gets lost and then you are stuck.

MR: You have no way to say oh yeah, I was in the G and it was going to the C minor.

RS: That's — yes. Basically it is that you know. And I believe that the classical musicians of the past, I mean the great composers, they reasoned like now we do with the jazz you know. Like there is one very simple process that has been the mechanism of music for a long time. That is the ability of creating a melody in connection with a certain harmony and vice versa. And so this one concept is universal. It applies to classical, it applies to jazz, to anything, you know. That's the relation between a melody line and the chord. Sometimes they can even be the same thing.

MR: Well it would be interesting to speculate if you could play a Beethoven piece when Beethoven was there and if you were taking more liberties than some other classical player, how he would respond to that.

RS: Well some of the great composers used to be very much enthusiastic to see that their compositions was transformed by someone else. Other composers, they didn't like that. But you see going back to the fact that I play classical music, I came up with this kind of desire. Like you know when we play jazz, we sometimes select a famous tune from the American songbook, and then we expose the melody and then we improvise on the tune. That's what happens. And then after the improvisation you go back to the melody and conclude. So this, I thought, why not we can't apply this concept to a classical music thing you know. Like for example Chopin wrote beautiful melodies, you know, the nocturnes and so for example I played the "Nocturne in E flat," number two, and if you analyze the tune it's basically a 32 bars song. 8 bars A section, then repeat, then a bridge, then again the 8 bars. And then there is a tag. But that's the way, the structure of the piece. So you can play the melody with those chords, you can even play it exactly the way Chopin wrote it, but then you can have some fun, try to improvise on that structure of chords. And that I find it very enjoyable. I mean I always, you know coming from classical and then falling in love with jazz, I always liked to fantasize like you know I wish someone like — I wish like there would be someone that could play classical as masterfully as Vladimir Horowitz, and then all of a sudden jump into the Oscar Peterson mode but with a seed of authenticity. Because what happens, those classical piano players, at least many of them that tried to go into jazz, when they played the jazz it didn't sound quite right. And vice versa. Sometimes jazz musicians who attempt to play some classical music, it doesn't sound quite right. I'm not saying that everybody's like that but you hear. So I'm thinking, okay, play a nocturne properly and then when you improvise try to be a Tommy Flanagan.

RS: Right. You've got to swing, and you know those chords stop being the Chopin thing but becomes the Hank Jones thing you know. And I love this transformation process. I had so many discussions with other piano players, colleagues, who in a way, they don't feel the necessity of doing such a thing. And I understand this point of view. Because they might say you know a beautiful masterpiece of Chopin or Schumann or Beethoven, it doesn't need anything else. It's all there. Why you have to mess it up? And my answer is that because I cannot help it. Because I am an improviser. And whenever I hear a very nice melody with nice chords I feel that this — I feel the urge of coming up with something else. I hope I explained it properly.

MR: You did.

RS: My English is a little —

MR: No it's a great sentiment. And I'm trying to picture you as seven or eight years old. Were you an outgoing personality back then? Because it seems to me, to have this urge to improvise or to make up new things, you can't really afford to be too shy.

RS: Well when I was little like that age, I could be engaged very easily in conversations with people. I wouldn't say that I was shy. I became a little bit shy later on, when I was a teenager. You know there is that transition of teenagers, but it was only a few years. By the age of 17 I was already playing almost a full schedule of gigs in the Milan area, and still going to high school and having to get up early in the morning. And I always loved the feeling of an audience listening to you. I always felt inspired by the audience, a good audience. Because it happens once in a while but it depends also where you are playing the gig. You know sometimes people get more or less involved. But I like to — I feel that I've got things to say in a certain way, musically. And so I need an audience to express these things. Because I can't just hold these things to myself. You do that when you practice home, by yourself. But then you've got to throw them out and let people know.

MR: You speak very well about the music and how it relates to other people. There's a quote I'm reading from your biography. And there's a quote here that says, "to play jazz and make it understandable to everybody is one of my goals."

RS: Yes. One of my obsessions is I'm worried of how much of the music that you play is understood by the audience. And when they understand it, to which degree. Because most of the audience is not aware of the movements of the chords for example. I mean we practice many many hours trying to find a very smart way to lead one chord to the other. We spend many many hours to find a way to come up with very smart, intelligent improvised phrases on top of certain chords, or a smart phrase that connects one chord to the next. So I asked myself, how many people are aware of these things that for us mean so much? Most of our practice is it. So probably very few can understand this kind of

the mood of our music because that's the emotion, what gets the audience is the emotion. And the other thing is that I care very much whenever I do something that might not be, or might be less easy to comprehend I like to explain to the audience what I will try to do, or what I just did. Because we have seen so many times concerts where the audience just sits there and is exposed to music, sometimes very great music, but without really connecting to the performance. So I don't want that. And if I sense that, to me it's an awful feeling. I want the audience to be part of it. And I want to try as much as I can to make them feel like they are part of the concert. You know? Because when the audience is receiving the message that you are trying to send, you sense that. And that feeling that you get from the audience is then your inspiration. So it's an energy that goes back and forth.

MR: What visual cues can you see in your audience?

RS: That's the problem with piano playing you don't have a visual. Because you are standing — the audience is on your side. So that's good for me. Because if I would be looking and for example I see one person yawning, then for me the night is ruined. So I don't want to see. I want to sense. I don't want to see. I want to sense.

MR: Well said. When you say that you might try something that could be a challenge for the audience, are you talking about that term we sometimes use about playing "outside" the chord changes or being more experimental with the harmonies, comparing your right hand to your left hand?

RS: Well I wouldn't say much of that, because I am one of those players that is very much inside the harmony, even though I like very much almost everything in the history of jazz. But you see I specialized from Fats Waller to Teddy Wilson, and then the bebop, and then of course as a piano player I fell in love with the Bill Evans world. And that's my thing is tonal jazz, so far. Then maybe one day I will feel the necessity to go in other directions. But for example, what I try always to explain to the audience is whenever I play one of these arrangements of a classical tune that goes into jazz I try to explain what's the process that brought me to do that and how I do it. In a very simple way, you don't have to make a conference, but it's enough just to say a couple of words just to make them aware of what is going to happen or what just happened. Because you see all my performances, when I'm the leader, are really improvised. I don't make a set list. So when I work with Eddie and Nicki they exactly know by now all these years, the kind of repertoire that I know and how I do it. So they are perfectly comfortable in letting me go wherever I feel to go. So sometimes I'll be playing a ballad and then I connect it to a classical tune without announcing it. But then after that I stop and there is the applause and then I explain to the audience what happened. Or if I decide before playing what I'm

important, to be in the moment. You know, don't go — in my opinion, I don't want to go on stage with a preconceived set list that is going to happen, this and this and this. Because it takes away all the fun of it. The most beautiful feeling is when you get in front of the piano and the audience and you are blank. And you have to figure out what's the right tune to play to make the people happy and yourself happy. And this was the approach that some of the greatest players used. I mean think of Errol Garner. Errol Garner never went on stage knowing what he was going to play you know. In fact, all those crazy introductions that he used to make up, he needed to do that to make up his mind what he was going to be playing. And the result was the audience went crazy because the audience would hear this completely far out introduction and then all of a sudden "I'm Confessing That I Love You" or one of those great songs. And it's beautiful. I mean it's beautiful. What can I say? It's beautiful. And one of the most fun of Errol Garner [habits] had was never tell the bass player which key you were going to play a song. And sometimes the night before he would play a certain song in E flat. And then two nights later he would play again the same song, I don't know, in A major. And the bass player, to figure out. And now on YouTube you see all these videos and you can spot on these videos that he's pleased with the fact that the bass player is just fishing around for the right chord you know. Nothing wrong with that. That's the beauty. Because jazz is about hearing, it's about connecting, it's about having fun. That's the way I see it.

MR: I can't think of a better way to say it. That was fantastic what you just said. I wonder how the bass players used to talk amongst themselves about, "hey have you played with Errol? What was that like for you?"

RS: Yeah. In fact you know there is only that I know one biography of Errol Garner. And he never, I think very seldom he did an interview. So this biography was put together by collecting what other people who worked with Errol and knew Errol had to say about him. And so this is what all the bass players that appear in this book, they say all the same thing, that they had to stand right there by the left hand. You know the piano is here and the bass player is standing there, because they had to try to catch what he was doing with the left hand whenever their ear wouldn't be fast enough. So they would look at — but then of course Errol would use, sometimes, voicings with the left hand where not necessarily the lower note was the note that the bass player is supposed to play. So the bass player is supposed to have some, also, kind of piano knowledge, to know that if he was playing a certain voicing, let's say with an A with the pinky, the lowest note, they were supposed to play an F for example, or, you know, things like that. It's very interesting. Very nice.

MR: Wow. Talk about spontaneity. If I was filming Nicki tonight specifically and watching her reactions to what you're doing, do you anticipate that you might do some things that she needs to like be totally zoned into with you?

RS: Well but she has so good ears that as soon as you put down your hand on a chord she's right away with the notes in the bass. These are — in the school of the great bass players — bass playing is not really, in my opinion, about amazing finger technique. It's about ears. It's about knowing the right note to put on a certain — it's about hearing what the piano player is doing. And whenever you throw some substitution chords, they can sense that you are going in that direction. See one more time, it's about sensing. That's very, very, very important. It's something that's very hard to teach in the schools. That comes, that kind of playing that is based on feelings and emotions and sensing things, it's about experience and about wanting to work in that certain way. I remember in Milan we had some fantastic bass players, you know, they could sight read perfectly with wonderful technique, perfect intonation, but some of them, they couldn't just play a song that they never heard before. While in New York City that's what you expect from any bass player. You start playing and then if they don't know a song after two choruses they can catch it.

MR: Yeah I'm sometimes mystified by bass players who don't seem happy with what you just described. To me, the bass is so important. And it seems fulfilling to be able to play that role as you described it.

RS: Yes. Absolutely. Absolutely. But it's true that some bass players, some musicians in general, are not, they don't feel at ease with this freedom concept. It's the opposite. They feel free when they have everything planned. For me it's the opposite. I feel caged when everything is planned. And my — how could I say — my idea is go to zero. It's very weird to explain. That's the way it is. I want to feel free whenever it's my gig. If it's someone else's gig then you've got to do what the bandleader wants. You know?

MR: I can picture if you had become a dancer instead of a piano player, that you would have chaffed at the idea of this choreographer telling you, "move here, then you move there and then you move like this."

RS: Yeah, yeah. But you know with players like Harry Allen, you know, wonderful tenor player. We go on stage and until the very last minute Harry doesn't know what he's going to play. And then he'll start something and we play it. That sometimes is risky but you know, I remember a few years ago with Scott Hamilton, another wonderful tenor player. I was exchanging this opinion of mine about the freedom of not having a set list. And I wanted to see what was his feeling about it. And he said, "thank goodness that at least there is one more person that thinks this way. I don't want to be thinking what I'm

play something. Why do I have to make a set list before?" So one time we had this duet concert in Italy. Just me and Scott. And it was a beautiful church and we had no microphones. Just the piano and the saxophone. And with the perfect acoustics. Not too dry but not too wet. You know what I mean? And so I said, "Scott, let's do this kind of concert. You start with any song you want. And if I know it I'll join you. Otherwise you play by yourself. And then I'll start with a song and of course you'll know it," because both Scott and Harry, they know everything. And we played one hour 15 minutes concert. One set. I was one hour 15 minutes of music. From one tune to the other without speaking one word. And the most exciting thing was the audience sensed right away what we were doing and they knew that there was nothing established before, and they were just, you felt like they were being part of that. And they were wondering, now what is he going to do. Now what is he going to — and it was the most beautiful. No one was afraid of making mistakes. Because when you get that kind of freedom, and you put one of the starting point is that — you know there's nothing wrong if you don't know a tune, you play by yourself. Now of course we were trying to play tunes that we kind of assumed that we knew. It's not that you really challenged someone just to play the most obscure stuff. Because that's — you want to play together.

MR: Yeah. Then it becomes sort of like a competition.

RS: Yeah. And that's —

MR: Like, "I'll bet you don't know this one."

RS: Yeah. That doesn't make sense. I mean you want to play together.

MR: I'm going to ask you to pull up that microphone clip a little bit, maybe up, yeah, good. It was just rubbing on your coat a little bit. So tell me about the kind of gigs you played in Milan when you were still a teenager. Were they all jazz gigs? Were they dance gigs?

RS: Yeah it's the usual combination that applies to this very day. Sometimes it's a concert in a jazz club. Sometimes it's a jazz concert in a theater. Sometimes it was a jazz festival. Sometimes it was just a restaurant gig, background. Sometimes it was a wedding. Now the trouble back then happened most of the time when you were engaged to play on parties, weddings or — because I learned very, very soon to make sure that the people that engaged the band were aware of the kind of music we played. Because if you show up and after three tunes they want to hear tangos and dances and then Michael Jackson tunes and stuff like that, I cannot play that kind of stuff. And so I remember very early as a teenager playing with other musicians that hired me, we would show up thinking of playing jazz and then here we go, the people are very unhappy because they want something else. And so some of those situations — now thinking back you think that they were kind of funny. But then, back then, it was a tragedy when it happened.

RS: But there was, then in Milan, and some of them are still around, a group of musicians, for example, the musicians that worked for the orchestra of the TV, the national TV, that they had the kind of training that allowed them to do anything. I mean they were mostly classically trained musicians that loved jazz, so very early they learned to improvise and the jazz repertoire. But then of course growing up, some of them, even in the 40s and 50s that was when there was so much work for live music that every musician was supposed to be playing anything. So you were supposed to know waltzes and mazurkas and tangos but also the American songbook and to improvise, the bebop, everything. So by starting to play very early with these guys I understood how important it was to be able to pull it off in any situation you know. Or to turn any situation that you know that it might end up — it might be a stinky situation — you have to be able to turn it into a success. And these guys were unbelievable. I mean there were singers that, they knew anything. Anything that someone, "could you do that?" "Oh yeah, of course." And then I learned very, very early, the importance of being able to fake a song. That sounds so bad, but it's a big part of musicianship, you know, just if you're not sure about something, you open your ears and you kind of fake it. You find your way through. And most of all you pretend like you know what you're doing.

MR: Very important. Yeah. This is what it's supposed to be, whatever I'm playing.

RS: Yes. Well you know that's part of it. And you see that also in great concert artists you know. Those beautiful videos that you see now of Arthur Rubenstein and Vladimir Horowitz. Sometimes their playing is extraordinary. It's out of this world. But they also made mistakes. They also — but you have to pretend like nothing happened. You cannot stop. You cannot make a face. You cannot make a face. You don't do that. You just carry on. That's very important.

MR: Was there, when you were playing these gigs as a teenager, what was considered rock & roll?

RS: Well this opens another — because for example when I was a teenager in Italy there was also this big wave of the so-called heavy metal music. So when we said rock & roll we even considered that being part of it. And I have to say that I could never relate to that kind of music that pounds way too much, said in very plain words. Very aggressive music in general. I don't relate to that at all. I think for the way I am and, once more, I want to make sure that that's just my opinion, I don't want to impose any of my ideas, but I think that I have to try to make the people dream, as a musician. I want to try to give the people some nice feelings. Because we are surrounded by garbage and nasty things all around constantly. As soon as you turn on the TV you have that pounding stuff. Very bad things happening in the world. You know you cannot watch anymore, a movie, without

governments, they make so many laws and this, they should prevent whoever, 99% of the stuff on TV about violence and killing. You know, because then once after, I'm going to get up and shoot the people. That's where they get the inspiration I guess. So I think that as a musician in my small, in a very humble way, I want to make people dream. I want to make people feel lighter. That's what I want to do. So it might be wrong or right I don't care. That's what I want to do.

MR: Well said. You made me feel lighter yesterday when I was listening to "St. Louis Blues."

RS: By the way, "St. Louis Blues" has been one of those tunes that Earl Hines had the wonderful rendition of that tune, and one of those tunes that became a tour de force for piano players you know. Even Willie "The Lion" Smith, the great stride piano player, he said that the greatest tune ever written was the "St. Louis Blues." Tommy Flanagan even recorded the "St. Louis Blues." So that's one of those tunes, like another one for example is "Tea for Two" — that all the great piano players, they came up with a signed version of "Tea for Two." There is the Fats Waller version, the Art Tatum version, the Bud Powell version, the Nat King Cole version, the Oscar Peterson version. It's one of those tunes that somehow piano players felt they had to say their own thing through that tune.

MR: I love that kind of composition that just has something that attracts it. When I play that tune I love the — I guess it's the first 8 bars going into the second 8, that harmonic transition is so hip.

RS: Yeah. Tommy Flanagan was once interviewed and said that what attracts him in a song is the structure of the tune and the chords. Because there is a way of using the harmony that when you play the tune you just feel like blowing on those chords, on those changes, it's the most exciting thing to do. So there are tunes that are constructed in a certain way, that they are just an invitation to jazz improvisation you know.

MR: Do you have a way of thinking about choosing chord substitutions?

RS: Yeah. Well I use very common substitutions, like of course the tri-tone substitution that every musician knows quite well. But you know really I started basically as a Dixieland piano player. But then about 15 years ago I met Barry Harris, that is the greatest jazz pianist, in my opinion, alive today. And Barry made me understand bebop you know.

MR: How so?

RS: Because you know, sometimes to understand something you have to be lucky enough to meet someone that you can watch close by what he's doing. Because there is a human way and a musical way that you can get only just by standing there. And all of a sudden I understood so many more things about music. And we are so used to reason with labels. You know? This is swing, that's Dixieland, that's New Orleans, that's bebop. But if we think of, for example, the early 40s, all the jazz was happening at the same time. Because

still around, but Bud Powell and Thelonious Monk, they were starting. So everything was happening at the same time. So there wasn't a distinction in time like we do today. This was the period that is a way to make it simpler but it does not reflect the reality. So there was Teddy Wilson and that kind of rhythm section playing with Charlie Parker and Dizzy Gillespie, that they were blowing the bebop stuff. But of course they say that Charlie Parker came from Lester Young. So sometimes I believe that the language evolves. Anytime I try to play, because I'm inspired by someone else, that's evolution. Because in the very moment that that material comes through you, it's going to come out different. You know. And that's it. So Bud Powell said that Art Tatum had a very strong influence in his playing and Billy Kyle too. Billy Kyle and Art Tatum were part of what Bud Powell tried to do. But then of course it came, Bud Powell, his own thing.

MR: I liked what you said about physically being next to or behind Barry Harris.

RS: Yes. Yes. Yes. Yes. And so all of a sudden I understood the beauty of that kind of music, that even today a large part of the jazz audience, especially the jazz audience that relates more to the very traditional jazz, the label, the bebop, like something you can't quite grasp. And that's not true. Because it's also true that many musicians that say about themselves that they play bebop, they do not play bebop or they don't play it properly, and they don't make it sound good. Whatever you play you have to make it sound good. So then you relate to the people. It has to be played properly, with passion, with culture and intelligence. You know it's very seldom these days, and it amazes me, like you go hear a chamber music group and they're playing on a stage in front of 2000 people with no amplification. With very soft instruments. You go hear a classical guitar recital in a big theater, no amplification. Now when there is a jazz group playing you've got very often a drummer that bashes away so they have to stick the microphone into the piano, and then the bass is not loud enough so amplify the bass and it sounds like an a bass guitar, and everything — and even if sometimes the audience is not aware but that kind of loud amplified sound is bothering them. Maybe even at the subconscious level. But it's bothering them. So why jazz musicians cannot shape their own sound, thinking of being into an ensemble, and so I'll play in a way that I'm not making you suffer. So the drummer is supposed to play quietly in a way that he can hear the bass and the piano. And the piano is supposed to play in a way that is not pounding away so that the clarinet player is completely exhausted. And then you have to learn how to leave space. That's another very important concept that sometimes we forget about. That the space is part of the music.

MR: Rests are your friends.

RS: That's right.

MR: I love what you have to say about the music and how important it is to you to get that across to people. Don't you feel that people listen more intently if things are not so loud?

RS: Oh yeah, of course. Of course. Because it's the same thing like when you have a very bright light right in your eyes, then you don't see anything. You are blind completely. And the ears work the same way you know. By the way, something else I wanted to say about the prejudice that sometimes some audiences have against bebop. If you think of Charlie Parker with strings. That's the most beautiful music that you can imagine, and that's bebop. He was the king of bebop, Charlie Parker. So and vice versa there is this kind of prejudice between musicians and the fans of very modern jazz. They think that traditional jazz is kind of old stuff. That's wrong. Because we have to remember that some of the greatest so-called Dixieland musicians were Bobby Hackett, one of the greatest trumpet players ever. Jack Teagarden, the greatest trombone innovator ever. These guys, Ralph Sutton, one of the most incredible pianists.

MR: Sure was.

RS: So think of those musicians before you express a judgement against a certain genre or style.

MR: Yeah and I don't think the education system helps that that much. Over the years I've gone to some of the conferences, the jazz education conferences. And they have next to no what we might call traditional jazz being performed. And sometimes the students feel that the history of the saxophone started with John Coltrane, which is a shame.

RS: Well when I was in Milan I was teaching also. I was in a jazz conservatory for seven years. And I remember that once one of my ensemble classes I took a recording of Zoot Sims with a quartet because I wanted the saxophone player to hear that kind of playing. And I was surprised that no one in the class ever heard of Zoot Sims.

MR: I'm wondering about, people ask often, what are you thinking about when you improvise?

RS: Well this is exactly my point of view. I mean improvisation, like making up music on the spot, is exactly the same process when we speak a language, when we communicate. So in other words, what I am saying to you right now, it wasn't prepared before. But it's made of words that we know. You know? Because if I could make up words that no one ever heard before there wouldn't be communication. So when we learn to improvise practically we learn to speak the words. The phrases. And so at first, you know, when you are a baby and you are learning, you can say a few syllables at a time, and then you learn to say mama and papa, and then little by little — and it's the same thing with music. How to speak a phrase on top of a certain chord. How to speak a phrase and we go back to what we were saying before. How to speak a phrase, a musical phrase, connecting two

know the words and you know the rules, the grammar and how to put the speech together and then you deliver it. That's the same thing. That's the same thing. And in the same way, like in spoken language there are styles you know. They way they spoke a hundred years ago was different from the way they speak now today. That's the same thing with music. The way they improvised and composed music 300 years ago is different from today, even though most of the times the rules are basically similar or the same. But it's different. It evolves. I don't know if that was a clear enough explanation.

MR: Yeah. It's clear and people have said that it's like a language. I think the part that's difficult is that the underlying chords as they shift, that you have to keep up with that.

RS: Right. Well the other thing that we have to keep in mind is that when you are improvising it's not really about throwing in right notes on top of chords. You have to act like you are a composer. It means that while improvising, okay, you say a phrase. You play a phrase. Then the next phrase should be kind of consequential, like to reaffirm what you just stated. And then you can keep going on on that kind of development of the same idea, up to a point, like you feel that it's time to introduce a new element. It's like composition. It's a faster composition. We have to think that the great classical composers in the 1600s, the 1700s, the 1800s and so on, they didn't have a tape recorder. They didn't have the records. So they were all great improvisers. But the only way to make people aware of their own music, the only way was to write it out. Chopin could improvise a ballad you know, no problem. But there was no one there with the recording equipment to catch that and then to print millions of copies and have the whole world marvel at the beauty of the music. So Chopin had to write it out, note after note. And then give it to a copyist and then to the printing. And then finally the people could buy the printed music and they could see who Chopin was and what kind of musical mind he had. There was no radio. So unless you had the chance to hear Chopin playing live, otherwise the only other option to understand his musical mind was to read the score of his compositions.

MR: Hear it in your head. Yeah.

RS: Right.

MR: You had said some time ago about being in the moment. But also in describing the way you were composing on the fly, you almost have to be thinking a little bit about what you just played and how long am I going to play this thing. So you're in the moment but you're —

RS: Yeah. It's the same thing that you do in the conversation, talking. Again. Because while I'm talking I have to keep in mind what I just said. Because I have to keep the idea flowing and then I have to look a little bit ahead because I know in which direction I want to go with — by expressing my concept. I want to follow that direction. Or at a certain

subject in my conversation. And it's the same thing in the playing of the music. Now if you're playing a solo piano concert I say it's like to make a monologue. A monologue? You say in English?

MR: Um hum.

RS: Right. *Monologo* we say in Italian. While if you're playing with a band of musicians then it's really like a conversation. Like you are listening to each other and reacting to each other in different ways you know.

MR: And the group interaction like that works better with certain combinations of people?

RS: Yes. Absolutely. Because you have to be with people that have got a certain common feeling about the music, that see the music in a kind of similar way. And there is musical and personal — how do you say — compatibility?

MR: Yes. Empathy.

RS: Yes. That's very important. So in other words if you like very much the way your colleague sounds and you like him or her very much personally, and there is an understanding, that's the most beautiful feeling.

MR: How would you say that in Italian?

RS: What?

MR: The most beautiful feeling.

RS: Oh. *La cosa più bella*. The most beautiful thing.

MR: All right. So just to wrap up. Do you think you'll spend the rest of your life in America?

RS: Well it's hard to say. Because I'll tell you something very funny. When I was still living with my parents, you know, I used to say — you know I stayed with my parents until I got married. I have nothing against this. You know here in America most of the kids, when they go to college they leave their families. I stayed with my parents until age 33, before getting married. Then I got married and I moved to the United States. But before meeting the one beautiful girl that I married, you know I was sure one hundred percent that I would have never left Italy. I loved my country and I felt everything was fine. I didn't have no problem. But then, coming to the United States I came across some exceptional musicians that I felt very much that I could learn from them. And I needed to learn from them. I wanted to evolve. And so everything happened very quickly. One thing led to another. And when you are in the moment you're not sure exactly where is the path going, but then when you look back you are amazed. And so I'm very happy to be here. I'm very happy to be working and to play with wonderful jazz musicians. You know I'm going to say one more thing to conclude this interview that might give you an idea. You see when I was in Milan, we felt, I mean myself and some of my colleagues in Milan, we felt that the way some American musicians played jazz was really special. And

musicians there was that kind of authenticity in the music, of course, it is the music of their own country you know. And so every time we knew that there was a famous American jazz players that would tour Italy and come to Milan or close by Milan we would go hear him. So we went to hear Tommy Flanagan in Milan. We went to hear Kenny Barron once near Modena. I went once all the way to Switzerland in Bern, almost 400 km from my own town to hear again the Tommy Flanagan Trio, and then Barry Harris came you know, almost every year. Still going there to Italy. So every time we heard one of these musicians playing we heard that there was something way superior. And so what happened was that when we would play gigs, with my Milanase colleagues, and one of us would play very well, the most beautiful compliment that we could tell each other was, "tonight you sounded like an American." You know? So this has got nothing to do with the politics. It's just the fact. Because we felt that the jazz of Coleman Hawkins, the American tradition, was the tradition to follow, the authentic tradition. And I don't want to offend no one. Because today, now twenty years went by and of course the music spread even more and there are some young musicians from all over the world that they play fantastic. But back then, twenty years ago, that's what we felt. We had this great admiration for the great American players. And we wanted to sound like them.

MR: I can't think of a better way to wrap this up. You have been totally fascinating.

RS: Thank you. It was a pleasure. And I have to admit that, as I told you before, that I love to tell my musical story on the piano to the audience. Whenever I get the opportunity of expressing the thoughts behind that musical story, I love to do it.

MR: Well I'm looking forward to hearing your musical thoughts at the piano as well, tonight.

RS: Thank you.

MR: Thank you Rossano.